

Substitute Lesson Plan — The Salem Witch Trials: You Be the Judge

U.S. History, 8th grade · one 45-minute period · runs itself on student devices — you do not need to know the history

Teacher: _____ Date: _____ Periods: _____

The one link students need

mcnamaraheath-c.github.io/lessons/salem-witch-trials/salem_you_be_the_judge.html

Also posted in Google Classroom. Works in any browser, no login. If it loads, everything works.

What this is

An interactive lesson: students review the real evidence used against five accused people in the Salem witch trials of 1692, give a verdict on each, then see what actually happened. The website teaches the content; the students' work product is the **paper Verdict Sheet** (copies in the folder / printable from the same site under /materials/). Collect the sheets — that is the assignment.

Write on the board

- 1. Open the Classroom link. Put on headphones if you use the Read Aloud button.
- 2. Fill in each row of your sheet BEFORE you click your verdict.
- 3. Do not refresh the page — it starts the lesson over.
- 4. Sheet gets turned in at the end. Name on it first.

Timeline

Min	You	Students
0–5	Hand out Verdict Sheets. Read the script below. Point at the board rules.	Log in, open the link, write names on sheets.
5–12	Circulate. Check every screen shows the lesson (parchment look, “You Be the Judge”).	Read the intro and the “Before you judge” boxes. Slower readers can press  Read Aloud.
12–38	Circulate. Enforce the “fill the row BEFORE you click” rule — that is the only rule that matters. About 5 minutes per case is on pace; at 25 min they should be near Case 3.	Work the five cases, filling the table row by row. Verdict → reveal → last column.
38–44	Announce: “Finish the pattern boxes and the writing on the back.”	Pattern screen, pattern fill-ins, Think & Write on the back of the sheet.
44–45	Collect sheets at the door.	Turn in sheets.

Opening script (read as-is if you like)

“In 1692, in Salem, Massachusetts, people were put on trial for being witches — and today, you are the judge. The website shows you the REAL evidence used against five real people. Your job: decide guilty or not guilty, on the evidence alone. Fill in a row of your sheet before you click each verdict — the sheet is what you turn in. Work quietly; the site can read to you if you put on headphones.”

Troubleshooting & the fine print

Built-in supports (students know these)

- **EN / ES** buttons, top right — the entire lesson in Spanish, including the voice.
-  **Read Aloud** — reads the current screen. Headphones please.
- **Click any image** to enlarge it (the old documents are worth a close look). Click again or press Esc to close.
- Dotted-underline words show a definition when tapped.

If something goes wrong

- **A student refreshed / closed the tab:** progress resets. Not a crisis — their paper sheet still has their answers; they can click back through cases in a minute or two.
- **A device won't load the site:** pair that student with a neighbor; both fill their own sheets.
- **Wi-Fi is fully down:** run it as discussion. The outcome summary below is everything you need: read each name, ask the class for a verdict by show of hands, then reveal the outcome. Students complete the back page (Think & Write) individually afterward.
- **No sound / no voices:** Read Aloud depends on the device; reading silently is fine.

Emergency outcome summary (only if running it as discussion)

- **Sarah Good** — poor beggar, accused first; refused to confess; hanged July 19, 1692.
- **Rebecca Nurse** — respected 71-year-old; 39 neighbors signed a petition for her; refused to confess; hanged July 19, 1692.
- **Tituba** — enslaved woman; confessed under pressure and named others; the only one of the five who lived.
- **Bridget Bishop** — tavern keeper; refused to confess; the first hanged, June 10, 1692.
- **Giles Corey** — refused to enter any plea; pressed to death, September 1692.
- **The pattern to land:** everyone who confessed lived; all 19 people hanged had told the truth and refused. None of the evidence would count in a court today.

Early finishers

- Go back to the case you were most wrong about and add one sentence to its evidence box: what fooled the court?
- Click into the document images (warrant, petition, Tituba's examination) and try to find a name they recognize in the 1692 handwriting.

Please leave a note

How far most students got, any tech problems, and any sheet collected without a name. Thank you!